Competitor Price Watch: The App I Build That Never Lets a Price Cut Catch You Off Guard

The Gap

Your competitor dropped their price at 9 AM. You found out at 9 PM.

In between, every shopper comparing the two listings saw one cheaper option - and it wasn't yours. By the time you noticed, the day's sales had already gone elsewhere. And the worst part: this isn't a one-time event. Competitors adjust prices constantly - a sale here, a quiet cut there, a bundle there - and a seller checking prices by hand can only ever see a snapshot of a moving target.

Manual price-checking has three leaks:

1. **It's slow.** Checking dozens of listings across marketplaces takes hours nobody has.

2. **It's late.** You find out about a cut hours or days after shoppers already acted on it.

3. **It's blind to the floor.** Dropping your price to match without a margin guard can turn a recovered sale into a loss-making one.

The sellers who win on price aren't watching harder. They have a system watching for them.

The App, Piece by Piece

The Competitor Price Watch app I build has five pieces that work as one system:

1. Competitor Tracker

You add the competitor listings you care about - the same products, the close substitutes, the shops your customers compare you with. The app watches those listings continuously, not once a day.

2. Price-Change Alerts

The moment a tracked listing changes price, you get an alert - what changed, by how much, and on which listing. No more finding out at 9 PM about a 9 AM cut.

3. Margin Floor Guard

Before any repricing happens, the app checks your floor: your cost, your fees, and the minimum margin you set. It never reprices below that floor. Matching a competitor is only a win if the sale still makes money.

4. Auto-Reprice Engine

You set the rules once: match the competitor, stay a fixed amount below, or hold your price and alert only. The engine applies your rules automatically, within the floor, so your listings stay competitive while you do other work.

5. Price History and Reports

Every change is logged - your prices, their prices, and what each change did to sales. Over weeks, you see patterns: who cuts on weekends, who discounts before holidays, which products are price wars and which ones customers buy regardless.

Why This Matters

Price is the first thing a shopper compares, and on a marketplace it is often the only thing they compare before clicking. A seller who reacts a day late doesn't just lose a day's sales - they lose ranking, because marketplaces reward listings that convert. Fewer conversions today means lower placement tomorrow, which means fewer eyeballs the day after. A late reaction compounds.

A price-watch system breaks that cycle. It reacts in minutes, protects the margin while doing it, and turns pricing from a guessing game into a record you can read.

The Business Impact (Illustrative)

Take a seller with 50 listings whose 10 bestsellers get undercut regularly. Say the undercut costs just 5 lost sales a day across those listings, at a $25 average order value. That is $125 a day - about $3,750 a month - walking to competitors, silently.

Recovering even half of those sales through faster reactions is roughly $1,875 a month back. And that counts only the recovered sales, not the ranking protection that comes with steady conversions.

These are illustrative figures to show the shape of the leak, not a client result. Your numbers depend on your listings, your margins, and your market.

How You Build It

This is the kind of tool you can build with vibe coding, piece by piece:

1. **Prompt template:** describe the tracker first - "an app that watches a list of competitor product URLs, records each price change with a timestamp, and alerts me within minutes."

2. **Build the tracker:** use v0, Lovable, Bolt, or Replit to build the dashboard - tracked listings, current prices, change history.

3. **Add the alert layer:** connect alerts (email, WhatsApp, or in-app) to fire on every tracked change, with the old price, the new price, and the difference.

4. **Add the floor guard:** store your cost and minimum margin per product; the engine refuses any reprice below the floor.

5. **Add the reprice rules:** match, undercut by a fixed amount, or alert-only - per product, not one rule for everything.

6. **Connect marketplace APIs:** where official APIs exist (Amazon SP-API, eBay APIs, Etsy API, TikTok Shop Partner API), use them for accurate, permitted price data rather than scraping.

7. **Deploy:** ship on Vercel or Netlify, and check the dashboard daily for the first two weeks to tune your rules.

Checklist

- [ ] List your 10 bestsellers and the competitors shoppers compare them with
- [ ] Set your cost and minimum margin per product - your floor, in writing
- [ ] Choose your reprice rule per product: match, undercut, or alert-only
- [ ] Turn on alerts for every tracked price change
- [ ] Review price history weekly: who cuts, when, and on what
- [ ] Never reprice below the floor, no matter how aggressive the competitor

The Bottom Line

You can't out-watch a market that moves all day. But you can build something that watches it for you - alerts you in minutes, guards your margin, and reprices by your rules, not your panic.

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